A Mantra Called Self-reliance

For 25 years, S. Chandrakala worked at a bag manufacturer before she decided to set up a small shop of her own six years ago. With her provident fund money and savings, Chandrakala bought two sewing machines. She now makes and sells school bags, raincoats, vehicle covers and mends all these. Self-reliance is a watchword with her.

"Before casting our vote, we need to think about and evaluate the candidates who have done good work"

"For our livelihood, we should not be dependent on anyone," she says. She casts her vote with the same independent spirit. Chandrakala lost her husband early and stays with her mother. The latter is a beneficiary of the state Congress government's welfare schemes, such as the Rs 2,000 monthly allowance for women heads of families and the free foodgrain scheme. With the Siddaramaiah-led government making bus travel free for women, Chandrakala saves about Rs 600 a month on her commute. She feels, however, that schemes focused on essentials like healthcare and education could come in more useful. ■

-Ajay Sukumaran

WHERE ARE THE JOBS?



ARUN KUMAR

Sunita Kumari, *27*
Agra, *MA Hindi*

Constituency: Agra

Issues that will decide her vote: Safety, development

Demands from the govt: Jobs, economic stability for Dalits

Sunita lives in a large joint family in the city's Mantola neighbourhood, home to several shoe-making units. She had applied for the UP Police SI (sub-inspector) entrance test in 2017, but the exam got cancelled after a paper leak episode. She still hasn't found a job, and she wants the government to do something so that Dalits can stand on their own two feet.

"The cost of education is too high for most families and, in Uttar Pradesh, it's of sub-standard quality too"

The cost of education is too high and it's of sub-standard quality, she says. Her family sitting around her nods in agreement when she says the price rise in essential commodities has become unbearable. Free ration is fine, but you can't survive on that alone when you don't have an income, she says. Over the years, her Jatav family has switched their political loyalties. This time too, she followed her family's lead in who she voted for. ■

-Manisha Saroop